

Choking: clear the airway, save a life

Choking happens when something blocks the airway and stops air from getting to the lungs. If the person can still cough or speak, the blockage is partial — encourage them to keep coughing. If they **cannot breathe, speak, or cough**, the airway is badly blocked and you must act right away.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES

Severe choking is an emergency

Call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK), or have someone else call, if a person is choking and **cannot breathe, speak, cry, or cough**, is clutching their throat, is going silent or blue, or becomes unconscious. If you are alone with them, give first aid first and call as soon as you can — put the phone on speaker.

First, tell mild from severe

MILD — LET THEM COUGH

- Can still cough forcefully, speak, or breathe
- Coughing is the most effective way to clear it

Encourage them to keep coughing. Do not slap their back or do thrusts yet; stay with them and be ready to act if it gets worse.

SEVERE — ACT NOW

- Cannot breathe, speak, cry, or make sounds
- Silent or very weak cough; clutching the throat
- Lips or face turning blue; looking panicked

Begin first aid immediately and get emergency help.

Adult or child (over 1 year)

- 1 Give up to 5 back blows.** Stand to the side and slightly behind. Support their chest with one hand and lean them well forward. With the heel of your other hand, give up to five firm blows between the shoulder blades. Check after each one to see if the blockage has cleared.
 - 2 Give up to 5 abdominal thrusts.** Stand behind them and put your arms around their waist. Make a fist just above the navel and below the ribcage; grasp it with your other hand and pull sharply inward and upward, up to five times.
 - 3 Keep alternating** 5 back blows and 5 abdominal thrusts until the object comes out, the person can breathe, or they become unconscious.
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FOR A PREGNANT PERSON OR A VERY LARGE PERSON

Do not give abdominal thrusts. Instead give **chest thrusts**: place your fist on the center of the breastbone and pull straight back, sharp and firm, alternating with back blows.

Baby (under 1 year)

NEVER GIVE A BABY ABDOMINAL THRUSTS

Use back blows and chest thrusts only. Support the head at all times.

- 1 5 back blows.** Lay the baby face-down along your forearm with the head lower than the body, supporting the jaw and head. Give up to five firm blows between the shoulder blades with the heel of your hand.
- 2 5 chest thrusts.** Turn the baby face-up along your other forearm, head still lower than the body. Place two fingers on the center of the chest (lower half of the breastbone) and give up to five quick, firm thrusts.
- 3 Keep alternating** 5 back blows and 5 chest thrusts. Call emergency services if the baby does not start breathing, and continue until help arrives or the baby becomes unresponsive.

If the person becomes unconscious

START CPR

1. Lower them carefully to the floor and **call emergency services now** (speaker phone) if not already done.
2. Begin **CPR**: chest compressions, and rescue breaths if you are trained. Follow the dispatcher's instructions.
3. Each time you open the airway to give breaths, **look in the mouth** and remove any object you can clearly see. Do not sweep blindly with your finger, which can push it deeper.
4. Continue until the person recovers or emergency help takes over.

AFTER A SEVERE CHOKING EPISODE

Anyone who needed back blows or thrusts — or who has a lasting cough, trouble swallowing, or a feeling that something is still stuck — should be checked by a medical professional, because thrusts can occasionally cause internal injury and small fragments can remain.

Prevent choking, especially in young children

- Cut food for young children into small pieces; encourage everyone to eat slowly and not talk or laugh with a full mouth.

- For children under about 4, avoid or modify high-risk foods: whole grapes and cherry tomatoes (cut them up), nuts, popcorn, hard or sticky candy, chunks of meat or hot dog, and raw hard vegetables.
- Keep small objects — coins, button batteries, marbles, small toy parts, deflated balloons — out of reach of babies and toddlers.
- Supervise young children while they eat, and keep them seated.

Sources

- American Red Cross — *Conscious Choking* first aid guidance (back blows and abdominal thrusts; infant back blows and chest thrusts). [redcross.org](https://www.redcross.org)
- American Heart Association (AHA) — first aid guidelines for choking and CPR. [heart.org](https://www.heart.org)
- Resuscitation Council UK — *Choking* (adult and paediatric) guidance. [resus.org.uk](https://www.resus.org.uk)
- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) / National safety guidance on choking prevention in children. [cdc.gov](https://www.cdc.gov)

Steps reflect widely taught Red Cross / Resuscitation Council first-aid sequences. Different training bodies vary in detail — follow your local first-aid training and emergency dispatcher's instructions.

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for hands-on first-aid and CPR training, which is widely available and strongly recommended. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Reuse and reprint freely.